Pastoral Psychology, Vol. 53, No. 5, May 2005 (© 2005)
DOI: 10.1007/s11089-005-2584-z

"God may NOT be a Person!": A Case of Cultural Construction of God Representations

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This article raises the fundamental questions of God representations: What is the origin and nature of God representations in the context of culture? The subsequent questions that flow from this major question include: What are the psychoanalytic notions of culture and cultural experience? And what is the relationship between the self and God representation? Given the emphasis placed upon the nature of "individual" representational experience in psychoanalytic literature, this article presents a challenge to psychoanalytic object-relations theory by explicating the case of the Korean cultural construction of God representations. The author argues that to understand one's images of God one needs to consider the relationship between the mental images one has constructed prior to one's acquisition of language and cultural constructs that are collectively represented and symbolically embodied through the use of language.

KEY WORDS: God representations; self; cultural construction; language; Korean culture.

Beginning with the publication of the journal *Imago* in 1912, Sigmund Freud (1856–1939) and his colleagues applied psychoanalytic principles to cultural creations such as the arts, literature, mythology, and religion. Freud and his followers often argued that images and representations of God were profoundly influenced by a person's intrapsychic relationships with father and mother. What psychoanalytic researchers are tapping into is an internal reification of a God-image that is internally experienced in early childhood, rather than some sort of aggregate memory of God's characteristics, perhaps taught to the child

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0031-2789/05/0500-0405/0 © 2005 Springer Science+Business Media, Inc.

by parents and institutional religion. This article is a critical response to this emphasis on internal, individual, and prelinguistic processes in the creation of God representations.

No school of psychology has devoted more effort to this enterprise than psychoanalytic object relations theory. The theoretical literature deploying an object relations theory perspective to religion dates back to the 1930s and is now rather substantial, including the work of such respected theorists as Donald W. Winnicott (1896–1971) and Ana-Maria Rizzuto. Since the publication of *The Birth of the Living God* in 1979, Ana-Maria Rizzuto has had a substantial influence on the psychological study of God representation. According to her, the origin of God-representations has to do with mental images constructed by personal relationships with primary care givers, prior to the acquisition of language. And yet, Rizzuto clarifies the scope of her research by stating that "I will not attempt, in this study, to extrapolate conclusions to other cultures, where other beliefs and religious systems provide a different God or representation of God. The Eastern world in particular requires another study suiting its cultural traditions" (1979, p. 221). It is in response to this methodological challenge that this article is being written. The role of cultural influences in shaping God representations is neglected in current psychoanalytic object relations theory. What is required is a theoretical framework that affords productive insights into the impact of culture on self and God representation.

From a non-Western point of view, one of the stumbling blocks attendant upon an examination of recent psychoanalytic literature on God representations results from the fact that there are no automatic connotations that "God is a person" within the Korean context. For example, the Korean terms for God such as *Ch'on-ju* and *hanunim* literally mean "heaven," which is derived from Korean Confucianism. In actual usage, there is a personal connotation to *Ch'on-ju* or *hanunim*. And yet, the impersonal image of God, particularly through the use of the language, does not always represent God as *a* person since the terms for God represent to Koreans some cultural meanings of "heaven" derived from Korean Confucianism.

Drawing on Korean cultural terms for God, this article is an exploratory study of the development of the self, the interaction of culture, and the formation of images of God. God representations emerge through the rich interplay of the development of the sense of self that is a representational construct and through various cultural components that are internalized through the use of the language. In fact, many psychoanalytic researchers have focused on the role of cultural experience in the creation of God representations. And yet, this article represents a significant departure from traditional psychoanalytic research methods on individual experiences. Using my personal narrative of the development of God-images within the Korean context as a "specific example" a case will be explored for the importance of developing a new model for the interaction of individual and collective representations of God.

CULTURE AND CULTURAL EXPERIENCE: PSYCHOANALYTIC DEFINITIONS

When Freud discussed cultural life in terms of psychoanalysis, his view of culture can be described as the on-going struggle between two unconscious instincts: Eros and the death instinct. In his book, *Civilization and its Discontents*, first published in 1930, Freud uses the words culture and civilization interchangeably to denote "the whole sum of achievements and regulations which distinguish our lives from those of our animal ancestors and which serve two purposes—namely to protect men [or women] against nature and to adjust their mutual arrangements" (1930/1961, p. 36). His idea of culture (civilization) has to do with a dualistic view of human nature. "After long doubts and vacillations," writes Freud, "we have decided to assume the existence of only two basic instincts, *Eros* and the *destructive instincts*" (1949, p. 20). His earlier dualism of sex and ego instincts is superseded by this distinction. For Freud, Eros is no longer thought of as simply identical with sexual libido, but as an exception to the conservative character of instincts (Freud, 1930/1961, p. 65; Freud, 1949, pp. 20–21). James J. Forsyth suggests that "it is only by understanding Eros as operating outside the conservative tendencies of instinctual life, or 'beyond the Nirvana principle,' that we can understand the fundamental distinction between the death instinct as a divisive principle and Eros as a unifying principle" (Forsyth, 1981, p. 84).

In Freud's view, civilization is born out of this instinctual conflict between Eros and death: "This struggle is what all life essentially consists of, and the evolution of civilization may therefore be simply described as the struggle for life of the human species" (Freud, 1930/1961, p. 69). For Freud, the cultural systems of civilization regulate interpersonal life through the repression of human aggressive impulses. As a way of repressing the divisive force of the death instinct, civilization (culture) serves Eros' goal of unifying. "Culture," as Paul Ricoeur puts it, "comes upon the scene as the great enterprise of making life prevail against death" (1970, p. 309).

In Freud's understanding of culture, culture is located *outside* in the visible reality of everyday living. I would argue that Freud does not fully apply his psychoanalytic point of view to culture. For him, culture is located in the public realm, not in the private psychic life of each individual. Freud writes, "The fact that these creations [cultures] of his [human being's] are not independent of one another, but are on the contrary closely interwoven, increases the difficulty not only of describing them but of tracing their psychological derivation" (1930/1961, p. 41). Given the neglect of cross-cultural differences and the overemphasis on the individual, Freud's theory of culture emphasizes only that cultures work for the sublimation of instinct. His concluding remark is quite clear: "The fateful question for the human species seems to me to be whether and to what extent their cultural development will succeed in mastering the disturbance of their communal life by the human instinct of aggression and self-destruction" (1930/1961, p. 92).

In the development of the psychoanalytic approach to culture, a singular debt is owed to Donald W. Winnicott (1896–1971), who created the concepts of "transitional phenomena" and "transitional objects." In the cultural areas of art, music, religion, and so forth, Winnicott notes that cultural phenomena are transitional in that they reflect both inner and outer reality. He discovers and names the transitional object, located in an intermediate zone between the mother and the child. He subsumes the transitional object under the heading "transitional phenomena." These phenomena, notes Winnicott, are the origin of creativity, at first expressed in illusion and play, and later in artistic contributions to culture.

Winnicott proposes to tackle Freud's treatment of culture: "Freud did not have a place in his topography of the mind for the experience of things cultural. . . . Freud used the word 'sublimation' to point the way to a place where cultural experience is meaningful, but perhaps he did not get so far as to tell us where in the mind cultural experience is" (Winnicott, 1971/1991, p. 95). It must be noted that Winnicott tries to distinguish "cultural experience" from culture, and uses the term cultural experience as an extension of the idea of transitional phenomena. Transitional phenomena include familiar intangible objects, such as songs, tunes, nursery rhymes, religious figures, or any number of representational experiences.

Winnicott seems to focus more on enjoyment of culture rather than the sublimation of culture. It may be that these matters are reflected in his favorable citation about Lionel Trilling, who says, "For [Freud] there is an honorific accent in the use of the word [culture], but at the same time, as we cannot fail to hear, there is in what he says about culture an unfailing note of exasperation and resistance. Freud's relation to culture must be described as an ambivalent one" (Winnicott, 1971/1991, p. 106).

For Winnicott, it is the location of cultural experience that is in question. He asks: "Where are we when we are doing what in fact we do a great deal of our time, namely, enjoying ourselves? Does the concept of sublimation really cover the whole pattern? Can we gain some advantage from an examination of this matter of the possible existence of a place for living that is not properly described by either of the terms 'inner' and 'outer'" (1971/1991, p. 106)? It is in response to these questions that his concept of transitional (potential) space as a third concept is proposed.

Having focused on the individual's "experience" of culture, however, Winnicott also seems to locate culture *outside* the person by defining culture as "something that is in the common pool of humanity, into which individuals and groups of people may contribute, and from which we may all draw *if we have somewhere to put what we find*" (1971/1991, p. 99). Freud's and Winnicott's perspectives on culture maintain an unavoidable dualism—culture as a whole (the common pool of humanity) and at the same time something that is sublimated (i.e., Freud) or experienced in the transitional space (i.e., Winnicott) by individuals. This leaves open

the question how culture as "something that is in the common pool of humanity" is collectively incorporated into the individual psyche.

A NEW NOTION OF CULTURE: BEYOND THE DUALISM OF CULTURE & SELF

If we only define culture as a complex whole, which includes customs, beliefs, morals, rituals, and languages, we would not be able to avoid the dualism of self and culture. That is, the psychoanalytic understanding of culture tends be limited to "high" culture, in other words, art, music, and literature that embody the Neo-Platonic notions of idealized beauty, perfection, and truth. And it tends to assume that these values exist in the abstract and are the same for all human societies. To articulate collective dimension of culturally constituted representations, a working definition of culture in this study is *a system of symbols*, or, alternatively, *the webs of meanings one has oneself spun*.

It should be noted that definitions of culture are contested in contemporary scholarship. Conflicting definitions abound. For the purposes of this article, one of the most important qualities of culture is that it is a shared phenomenon that is simultaneously "inside" and "outside" of the person. One of the most useful approaches to these issues is the work of Clifford Geertz. I accept Geertz's "interpretivist" definition of culture given in *The Interpretation of Cultures* (1973): "the webs of significance [man or woman] has himself [or herself] spun" (p. 5). He is best known for his ethnographic studies and for his theoretical writings about the nature of culture. The most influential aspect of Geertz's work has been his emphasis on the importance of the symbolic—of systems of meaning—as it relates to culture, cultural change, and the study of culture. Geertz argues that culture is "public because meaning is" (1973, p. 12)—systems of meaning are necessarily the collective creation of a group. A system of meaning is a set of relationships between one group of variables (e.g., words, behaviors, rituals, symbols, and so forth) and the meanings which are attached to them. Language is the most common example of such human meaning systems. The individual is not, as in the psychoanalytic model, a passive, remote (or repressed) member of a given society; it is rather, an active spinner of cultural webs. The role of spinning signifies a capacity for mental and collective representations.

In this sense, culture is both outside and inside of us. Culture is not fixed, but an ongoing construction—that is, we are all engaged in the process of creating, exchanging, and interacting through this medium. In order to avoid the notion of culture as homogeneous, static wholes, this article reconceives culture as an adjective (i.e., *cultural*) and plural noun (i.e., cultural *experiences*—both internal and collective cultural experiences). In this study, culture will be explored by looking at modes of representations—that are both individual and collective.

Culture is necessarily involved in the ongoing interaction between individual and collective representations.

A NEW NOTION OF GOD REPRESENTATIONS: WEAVING SELF AND CULTURE

In traditional psychoanalysis, the thrust of the experience of God is that God is mentally internalized by the object relationships with significant others in early childhood. As such, the God representation must be a product of "individual" mental representation. In this article, mental representation of God includes, but is not limited to individual, internal representation of object (i.e., God representation as one's early internal object representation of father/mother). The focus of this study is placed on "collective" cultural experience. I will argue that cultural meanings are "collectively" represented in the development of God representations in Korea, which might be different from the traditional concepts of the Christian God.

Drawing from cultural and historical phenomena (i.e., the use of Confucian terms for God in Korea), the major investigative questions in this article focus on how to construct a model to explore the psychodynamics that affect not only psychological structure (i.e., the "object-relating" dynamics of the self), but collective formations of God representations in Korea (i.e., the "object-relating" dynamics of cultural group). To appreciate the interaction of culture in the formation of God representations, this study suggests not only the significance of one's image of God, but also the interaction of that image in relation to the self. Peter C. Hill and Todd W. Hall point out: "one's self-image is not independent of God images nor the interaction between God and self" (2000). For instance, for the person in sudden financial crisis, the interaction between God and self might be characterized and experienced as help-obtaining. The relational schema in representing God and self is based on the image of helper (God) and of being helped (self) and the interaction between the two. The schema itself will no doubt be influenced by socially-defined conventional roles (i.e., how both a helper and a person being helped typically behave in a given society).

The nature of the interaction between God and self are crucial to the study of self and God representations in Korea. This article will examine the view that the relational schema representing God and self in the Korean context is heavily influenced by cultural symbol systems. For the person in the Korean Confucian context,[3] how is the interaction between God and self characterized

[3]Despite the fact that it was the syncretic overlap of Korean religious cultures (e.g., Confucianism, Buddhism, Taoism, and shamanism) that provided the context for the acceptance of Christianity, this article will focus only on the role of Confucianism since this study will explore the birth and development of the Confucian terms for God (i.e., *ch'on-ju*) when Korea's first contact with Christianity was made in the seventeenth century—At the time, Confucianism was the state religion. The Confucian terms for God will be reviewed in terms of the earliest collective representation of the Christian deity in Korea. For a wider review of the syncretic nature of Korean religious cultures, see

and experienced? Noting the fact that the Korean term for God means "heaven," what is the Confucian image of "heaven" in Korean context? What is the collective representation of personhood in a Confucian society? How are both a person and "heaven" typically related in Korean Confucian traditions? How can we understand the relationship between individual and collective representations of God?

THE CONSTRUCTION OF THE SELF IN KOREAN CULTURE

In the Western social sciences in general and in psychoanalysis in particular, the concept of the self, based on major Western philosophical thinkers such as Descartes and Kant, may be characterized as a rational, self-conscious and autonomous agent. The psychoanalytic object relational model moves beyond a solely intrapsychic view of the self in terms of the self's relational nature to others, especially one's mother. Object relations models claim that the self has a deep structure within the psyche as an "internalized" pattern of relationality.

The idea of "object-relations" in psychoanalysis and its clinical application reflect a relationally based model of healing. In recent years, there has been much emphasis on its application to the areas of pastoral counseling and psychotherapy (Cooper-White, 2004). The assumption on which therapeutic goals of relationality are based has to do with the Western construction of the self. In other words, the object relations method is largely based on the self-reliance of the autonomous actor. The individual exercises personal control and is the causal agent responsible for changes in his or her environment, including personal relationships. This is reflected in vocabulary which depicts the individual as someone who "initiates," "builds," "maintains," "develops," "works on," and "breaks up" a relationship.

Faced with the current developments in psychoanalysis, from Freud's "one-person intrapsychic theory" to the object relations theory's "two-person interpersonal approach," (Slipp, 1988, p. 33) this study proposes that there is a need for revisiting Winnicott's object relations theory in order to better understand both personal and collective representational processes of the self. In Freud's drive theory, the object is created by the experience of drive satisfaction. He posits the notion of an object outside of the self. And yet, Winnicott expands the notion of object-relations by taking seriously the concept of "internal object." By distinguishing between the internal object (image) and external object, his view helps us to understand in more detail the relationship between internal psychic phenomena and the impact of external experience on the mental representations. For example, when a person has a collective symbol of God in a cultural realm, it is the process of how this object is internalized that is in question.

Chung, D. (2001). *Syncretism: The religious context of Christian beginnings in Korea*. (K. Oh, Ed.). Albany, New York: State University of New York Press.

Winnicott's understanding of "transitional phenomena" will be utilized to explore both psychological and cultural interactions between the self and internal/external objects.

In the Western culture of the autonomous self, God is considered as the "other" to the self. In this culture, the image of God is internalized as an "object" in the individual psyche. Accordingly, the understanding/imagination of God as a person is plausible. In the Judeo-Christian tradition, one essential aspect of God is understood as a divine being with whom a relationship can be established such as that found in the relational theology of Martin Buber's "Eternal Thou." Such a God allows its self to be known only to the extent that people are willing to engage it through a personal relationship. Autonomous agents are needed to have personal relationships with God.

Representing one's God as a person and having a personal relationship with God in the Korean context might be more complicated than in the Euro-American context, because Koreans do not clearly separate the autonomous and relational dimensions of selfhood. The former is not used as an instrument to "create" the latter. Rather, both are simultaneously present and inseparably integrated. This basic self-orientation results in a different perception of relationship and different representational experience of the self-in-relation.

Traditionally the difference between the self in Asian cultures and European societies has been the polarized notions of the "collective" and "individualistic" self (Markus & Kitayama, 1991; Kim, Triandis, Kagitcibasi, & Hakhoe, 1994; Triandis, 1995). As a Korean, my intercultural (both pastoral and clinical) experiences with people from different cultural backgrounds have not always confirmed this simple individualism-collectivism dichotomy. This dichotomy may function as an obstacle to an accurate understanding of a particular culture. The paradigm is too culture-bound. For instance, in the clinical encounter it is the individual who is the focus, not culture. In my view, culture is not a discrete entity, and has no precise boundaries.

An individual's culture can be explored through the lens of his or her representations—both individual and collective. In our cultural worlds, we are all engaged in the process of creating, exchanging, and interacting through the modes of representations. Neither "collectivistic" culture nor "individualistic" culture, for instance, should be simply pigeonholed into the public sphere; rather cultures are mentally and collectively represented in people's psyches. In turn, people's psyches are shaped and reshaped through cultural dynamics. It is the mutual interaction between self and Korean culture that is in question. I think that everyone, regardless of their culture, has both an individualistic *and* collectivist construction of the self. It is a matter of which self-construction predominates, and what socio-cultural elements determine the degree to which it influences one's behavior. In the Korean context, the socio-cultural elements that determine the nature of the self are based upon Confucian family systems.

CULTURAL REPRESENTATIONS OF GOD: RIZZUTO AND SPIRO

Rizzuto is among the first who heavily draws upon Winnicott's object relations theory to study God representations. I do not intend to provide an exhaustive review of Rizzuto's psychoanalytic work on God representation. And yet, I point to the fact that Rizzuto does not examine the impact of socio-cultural factors on the representational process. Rizzuto's framework only works within the intrapsychic realm: that is, one's intrapsychic relations with the primary caregiver. For Rizzuto, cultural experience is internal and individual in nature although this experience always involves others (e.g., mother). And yet, it is of interest to note that Rizzuto cites the anthropologist Melford E. Spiro's definition of religion: "an institution consisting of culturally patterned interactions with culturally postulated superhuman beings" (Spiro, 1966, p. 96; Rizzuto, 1979, p. 3). Interestingly, in her research method, she does not note the workings of an institution consisting of culturally patterned interactions with cultural symbols of God. As she seeks the indisputable psychological conditions and antecedents for religious belief in God, Rizzuto pays little attention to cultural representations of God.

Melford Spiro (1920-) is one of the leading figures in psychological anthropology who claims that Culture and Personality Theory is not merely a sub-discipline of anthropology, but a distinctive theoretical approach to various problems, such as religion (more specifically, God representations), posed by the investigation of cultural systems. Spiro is among the first to point to a comprehensive explanation for the God-representations, with respect to both his anthropological (cultural) argument *and* psychoanalytic (mental) argument (Spiro, 1987). His work is focused on the relationship of cultural symbols, collective meanings located prior to and outside of the individual, and also becoming an integral part of the person's cultural representations.

Spiro claims that beginning at birth children develop *socially-constituted* conceptions of the world as a consequence of transactions with parents or other primary caretakers. This view intersects with Rizzuto's thesis on the formation of a God representation in early childhood. Spiro's account of the "socially-constituted" representations of parenting figures is constructed in such a way that they are developed prior to the acquisition of language and the *culturally-constituted* representations which language makes possible.

In his essay, "Collective Representations and Mental Representations in Religious Symbol Systems," Spiro (1987) suggests three dimensions of the problem to which a comprehensive explanation for God representations must attend: (1) the *private*, as well as *public* meanings of religious symbols; (2) their *deep*, or *socially acquired* meanings, as well as their *surface*, or *culturally transmitted* meanings; and (3) the *latent*, as well as the *manifest* functions of the religious actor's belief. Any "explanation that ignores any of these dimensions is," as Spiro contends, "incomplete" (p. 183).

Spiro does point to the significance of these three dimensions; however, he does not explain how these dimensions are correlated—that is, the relationship between mental and collective representations. While Spiro heavily draws upon psychoanalysis to understand the dynamics of mental representations, he provides no explanation for the origin and nature of collective representations of God. At this point, it may be that Spiro's perspective on three dimensions offers a useful framework in order to examine both individual and collective representations of God in the Korean context where cultural meanings of God are embedded in people's linguistic experience.

Accordingly, this study will be an exploratory and constructive enterprise to examine the viability and value of bringing object relations psychology (Winnicott and Rizzuto) and psychological anthropology (Spiro) together to expand the field of religion and psychology. Methodologically, it will attempt to construct an interdisciplinary model to integrate psychic and collective understandings of cultural experience as essential to multicultural pastoral theology. A case study is used in order to argue that culture is not only inside or outside the person, but is also an interaction between the two, and that God-representations are best understood as an emergent from mutual interactions between mental representations and collective representations. Cultural interactions influence the way experience is interpreted, and helps to re-image and construct diverse meanings in multicultural contexts of pastoral counseling and psychotherapy.

The field of religion and psychology has been profoundly influenced by psychoanalytic ways of thinking and by Euro-American assumptions. This study seeks to expand the field to embrace the importance of culture in the construction of the self and representational experience. It is also significant, because pastoral counselors emphasize the significance of God-images as central to the identity of the Christian pastoral counselors and to the healing process of the client (Jordan, 1986; Howe, 1995; Armistead, 195; Graham, 1997). What is at issue here is whether or not they are able to deal with diverse cultural origins and their impact on representational processes of God-images.

Now, I use my own personal narratives to explore the process of building a critical and constructive model and method that will more adequately address the creation of God representations in cultures other than Europe and America. Using this case example of collective, cultural God representations in Korea, this study will attempt to show that cultures are not simply extraneous, but essential in exploring God-images in pastoral theology.

CASE STUDY: "GOD IS TRANSCENDENT *AND* IMMANENT HEAVEN"

I am a fourth-generation Korean Christian. At times in my personal, religious, and ethnic experience, the terms "Korean" and "Christian" can be an oxymoron. The term "Korean," as national identity seems to signify a cultural boundary situated far from the cultural location of Christianity (i.e., the West). And yet,

the story of the formation of my own collective (cultural) representation of God shows that a part of my Korean culture located *within* my psyche has helped me indigenize the concept of God to the point that Christianity becomes, for me, a *new* Korean religion.

I was born into a family who had been pious Christians for over four generations. I am the only son of the family. My maternal grandfather, a Presbyterian pastor, and all my family named me Soo-Young, the literal meaning of which is "to be called out for God's glory," as an answer to their prayer to have a son and vow to God to make me a minister. By the time of my high school graduation, my resolution to become a pastor was very weak since the image of "unworldly" sacredness was a psychological burden for me. My image of "being a pastor" was constructed by my experience of my maternal grandfather, whom I saw as a "saint." After retiring from parish ministry, he lived with my family in the same household. I never had a single bad impression of his religious life, daily activities, or even his face. To me, being a pastor, therefore, meant being a saint. During my childhood, my fear of being a clergyman had been mounting gradually. In short, I lost confidence in myself.

From my elementary school period, I began to take "preventive measures" against being a pastor. I planned to be a scientist. It was an act of deliberate and premeditated hope not to be a minister, since I felt that scientist was the most distant job from the minister. At that time, how did I formulate my God representation? Donald W. Winnicott says that "there can be found the tendency to dwell either on a person's life as it relates to objects or else on the inner life of the individual" (1971/1991, p. 105). My first image of God may have arisen from my inner life experience with a parenting figure: my early representation of God was "old person (grandfather) in heaven." I understand this is also a common Western Christian image of God. At this point, however, it may be worth restating that child rearing among Koreans is a communal affair—not merely one mother and father, but, perhaps most importantly, grandmothers and grandfathers. That is, a relationship with grandparents may become a decisive factor in the formulation of the image of God in the Korean context. In my case, I had lived with my maternal grandparents from my early childhood years. My maternal grandfather was, as Erik Erikson says, the "Ideal Prototype" during my play age—between the ages of three and five (1959, p. 166). Ana-Maria Rizzuto notes that "the first conscious God representations appear between the ages of two and three" (1979, p. 178). And yet, I do not remember my first God representation at two or three (prelinguistic period). After acquisition of language, however, my culturally-constituted image of God was *hanul* (heaven), for Koreans speak of god as *hanunim*, which means "the heaven" (more specifically, honorable heaven; *nim* is a suffix used to honor other person). Intrapsychically, the dualism of heaven (God) and earth (human) may have begun with my acquisition of the term *hanunim*. And yet, my spatial dualism has diminished as I came to learn about the cultural meanings of "heaven."

Some would say that *hanunim* does have some anthropomorphic connotations by containing the suffix, *nim*. Even if Koreans have some anthropomorphic connotations to *hanunim*, I will argue that Koreans have some other crucial connotations to the term. For this term holds some cultural connotations in terms of the collective representation of Confucian meanings of "heaven." What is then the meaning of "heaven" in American and Korean contexts? Are they the same?

In English, there is a connotation of paradise, a city of glorious light, a pleasant place after death, a reward for a good life, escape from hell, or Celestial Jerusalem. In the Korean context, Confucian meanings of "heaven" have both *transcendent* and *immanent* dimensions all at the same time. In Korean Confucianism, *Ch'on* (Heaven) is transcendent in so far as it produces things and humankind, and it is immanent in so far as it is ubiquitous as the cosmic principle which is manifested as heaven and earth. "Heaven" is outside *and* inside of us. At issue, then, with the cultural meanings of "heaven" is not the transcendent meaning, but rather the immanent meaning.

It is vital to notice that heaven as an immanent image of God is not the same as an anthropomorphized image of God. The anthropomorphizing process is grounded in the traditional Western sense of self that is considered as independent of other selves or God. In contrast, an immanent image of God does not focus on how *I* relate to God or how God is related to *me*, but rather focuses on the inseparably relational dimension of God and the self. It has much to do with the Korean sense of the selfhood, in which the self is necessarily connected with the other.

The implication is that those Confucian meanings may create strikingly different images of God—that is, a transcendent God and immanent God. Or some would come up with some ambivalent images between the transcendent and the immanent. In short, cultural meanings of "heaven" have a motivating influence on the way in which God (*hanunim*) is represented and embodied in families, churches, and society.

I would insist on the point that cultural meanings deserve emphasis in the studies of Korean God representations, not because the root or original meaning of a word is conscious to the ordinary speaker in Korea, but because those underlying cultural meanings are collectively represented by the Korean ordinary speaker through the use of that particular term.

It is of interest to observe that psychoanalytic theorists such as Paul W. Pruyser point to the contribution language makes to the formation of mental images. Pruyser writes: "[H]umans learn to think in terms of the language with which they grow up. Especially in regard to nouns, the nameability of anything vouchsafes its existence in one form or another. Naming, therefore, is bound to have a bearing on the production and form of mental images" (1983, p. 31). In this sense, my first attempts at naming God as *hanunim* (honorable heaven) appear to refer to specific objects: God (*hanunim*) means the heaven (*hanul*) in its concreteness and

specificity. It might be possible for Korean children, using the word *hanunim*, to represent God with some collective pictorial features (i.e., something about/like heaven) in the formation of mental images of God. As Pruyser points out, "when an image is conjured up by a word the imagination tends first to produce the representation of a specific exemplar of the class of objects to which the word refers" (1983, p. 31).

In terms of the composition of the word *hanunim*, it is most likely that the earliest developmental form of words is auditory. In other words, Korean children repeat very similarly pronounced words *hanunim* (God) and *hanul* (heaven) and hear themselves speaking them. At this stage there is no knowledge of the printed word, or even of printed letters. However, as Pruyser puts it, "words are at any rate not things or persons—nor are word sounds natural noises" (1983, p. 37). It is critical to note that words such as *hanunim* and *hanul* are symbolic entities. Symbolic entities signify a function to engage in representational experiences between persons. Words become the basis for all other symbols: that is, all other symbol systems can be *interpreted* only by means of language.

It is critical to notice that the Korean term for God is made up of two words (*hanul* and *nim*), each one having its own meaning (i.e., heaven and honorable). The word God itself, in Euro-American context, has no other meaning but God. That is, the individual letters—G, O, and D—do not contain any meanings.[4] In contrast, the term *hanunim* itself necessarily generates an object representation of "heaven."

Surely, the term "God" can never be imageless. One can, therefore, surmise that imagery (mental representation) of the term God has much to do with other object representations—that is, the human being's need to seek contact with his or her environment (outer reality)—in the Euro-American context where the term God or Gott is used.

In the studies of Korean God representations, it is necessary to take the role of language seriously as a culturally constituted representation. In this sense, Joyce O. Hertzler rightly defines language as "a culturally constructed and socially established system . . . of standardized and conventionalized . . . symbols, which have a specific and arbitrarily determined meaning and common usage for [the] purpose of socially meaningful expression, and for communication in the given society" (1965, p. 30). Humans live in a world of meanings. The objective world without meanings has no reality for humans—*hanul* (heaven) as an external object does not exist without meanings for Koreans. Meanings are neither static entities, nor are they entities that are merely bestowed on humans and learned by habituation. Meanings are conceived as communal products as they engage in social

[4]The etymological origins and meanings of the word "god" are unclear. The word "god" is not etymologically related to "good." The word probably comes from an Indo-European *ghut*, meaning "call," and if so the underlying meaning of "god" would be "that which is invoked." See Ayto, J. (1990). *Dictionary of word origins*. New York: Arcade Publishing.

interaction. For instance, Korean individuals may influence the many meanings of *hanul* that form their own society, as well as being influenced by these meanings themselves. These socially-created and socially-shared meanings (e.g., transcendent and immanent heaven) function in influencing the behavior (or collective movements) of individuals and groups.

Language describes all other social objects, all that people point out to one another in interaction. That is, language is used to "collectively represent" a part of reality. The term for God, *hanunim*, for example, "takes the place of" its referent (e.g., heaven as object). The word *hanunim* (God; honorable heaven) can be applied to a host of things once its meaning is grasped by the person. That specific object named *hanunim* can contain the meaning: a "highest" one, an "awesome" one, or a "great" one. Each of these meanings is a category that tells us what the object *hanul* (heaven) has in common with other objects and what some of its differences are. The hermeneutical significance of the word *hanunim* leads to a need for an interdisciplinary method to explore the development of collective God representations in a specific cultural context.

Turning to my story, regardless of my hopes of going to an engineering college, I first had to serve as an assistant to a chaplain in the army to fulfill my military obligations. During my service in the military church, I happened to read Dietrich Bonhoeffer's book, *Prisoner for God*. It sparked my understanding of the concept of "sanctification" which I previously understood in terms of a dualism of holiness (heaven) and worldliness (earth). After reading Bonhoeffer, my understanding radically changed to the new belief that following Christ should take place within the secular world by manifesting responsibility toward maginalized people in our daily lives. It was an "intensification" type of conversion in that this experience was the transformative event that healed my burden and bias (Rambo, 1993, p. 13). Imbued with hopes for the realization of what Bonhoeffer called the "one and only reality" of Christianity—that is, "God's reality in the world's reality"—I entered the College of Theology after finishing my military service. My family welcomed my decision. The question which intrigues me is this: What was going on inside of me in terms of the formation of my God representation?

In college, I broadened my narrow thoughts about Christianity and remedied my intolerant views of ministry. In retrospect, every single experience of my extracurricular activities in my college years was an obvious sign of divine grace, in which I felt God's love manifested through my ministry. My understanding of ministry was, in Bonhoeffer's terms, "existence for other people" in daily life.

Now, what kind of inner God-representation do I have? Do I hold a culturally-constituted image of God as *hanul* (heaven)? I feel that I still understand and experience God as heaven except that there is a shift, adaptation, or synthesis of meaning. Rizzuto writes: "God cannot be fully repressed. As a transitional object representation he [or she] is always potentially available for further acceptance or further rejection" (1979, p. 179). In my Confucian culture, as well as in my

experience, God "has a special place, because he [or she] is the cultural creation offered to men [or women] for their private and public (in official religions) reelaboration of those primary ties that accompany each of us 'unto the grave"' (Rizzuto, 1979, p. 179). My prelinguistic experiences with my loving parents and grandparents may have led me to construct mental representations of God as loving. After my acquisition of language, God's characteristics are subsequently conveyed through *hanul* (heaven), the symbol of my Confucian culture. A holistic understanding of my God representations may be measured in terms of the extent to which my projections of parental images are assimilated to (or rejected by) my culturally-constituted image of God whose existence is taught by my own cultural, traditional-religious concepts.

When I was first introduced to God by my parents, I created as well as found God. In the process of socially-constituted *and* culturally-constituted God-representation, I both "found" the external object, grandfather (heavenly, holy figure), and I "created" the internal object, *Ch'on* from my Confucian culture (See Fig. 1). The diagram shows how the Winnicottian model of creating and finding God can be collaborative with Spiro's model of socially-constituted (i.e., mental) and culturally-constituted (i.e., collective) God representations.

Since I was raised in a Christian family and church, I used the term *hananim* ("the only one") for the Christian God, while others (non-Christians) were using the term *hanunim* (the Heavenly being) for deity. However, the cultural symbol of *hanul* (*Ch'on*; the Heaven) was never displaced from my God-representation. In my childhood, due to the transcendent image of heaven as my first God representation, I experienced so much pressure to be a minister—a "transcendent" man of God. Was my internal object "destroyed?" After reading Bonhoeffer, my internal object, *transcendent heaven*, was integrated with a new object, *immanent heaven*. My previously one-dimensional God became more complex and inclusive. In fact,

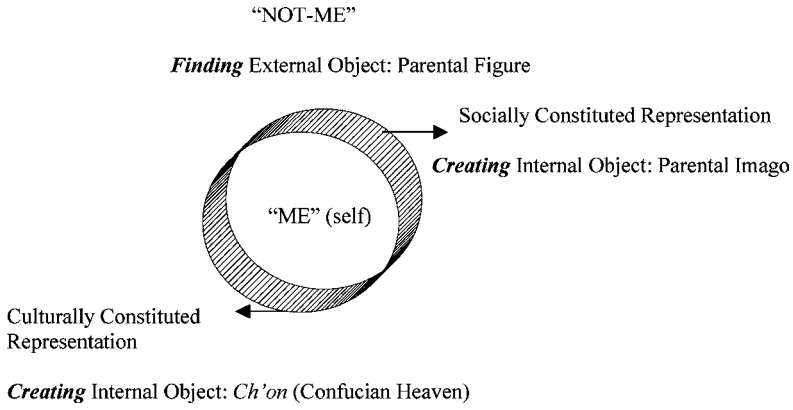


Fig. 1. Integrating Winnicott's and Spiro's models for God representations.

it was a "healing." I could easily accept Bonhoeffer's non-religious interpretation of Christianity. Naturally, I came to be absorbed in the theological movements of participation (e.g., liberation theology, and Minjung theology, etc.). The development of my God representations after the acquisition of language was shaped by the interaction between my mental and collective representations (or, in Spiro's terms, between socially-constituted and culturally-constituted representations.). And it is my contention that the collective images of God as "heaven" have influenced the "indigenous" development of the Korean Christian movement and theology (Kwon, 2003).

CONCLUSION

The subject matter of psychology and anthropology are distinct, but how and where to mark the division is unclear. For instance, in terms of the location of culture, culture is located both "out there" and "in here"—that is, in the public world and in the internal sphere of the self. There might be a middle position that "the locus of culture [is] inherently ambiguous and [can] not be adequately characterized in exclusively psychological or social terms" (Shore, 1996, p. 51). The point is that culture overlaps with both internal (psychic) and collective (social) aspects of human life, but it may be also something else. One possible exploration of the "something else" is presented in this article, by critically examining Winnicott's concept of transitional phenomena—that is, intersubjective (neither subjective nor objective) nature of representational experience. Winnicott's model has been utilized to probe how God as a special transitional object is both created and found on a collective (social) level as well as an intrapsychic level. Using the case study of my own God-representation, I suggest that we live with both mental and collective representations, and both representations are equally important. This case has been explored for the importance of developing an interdisciplinary model for the interaction of mental and collective representations of God in the fields of pastoral theology as well as psychology of religion. The question of which representation takes effect in a conflictual situation between dissimilar individual and collective representations will be crucial for future consideration.

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